

Minuet and trio

A well-known use of the ABA form can be found in the “minuet and trio” structure. The minuet is a short dance-like form in 3/4 time, with a strong downbeat and a waltzlike sound. The trio is usually more lyrical, with legato phrases to contrast with the minuet. Often the second appearance of the minuet is not written out, but the entire form is printed as Minuet, Trio, Da Capo al Fine.

Minuet

Trio

Minuet da capo

In the final A section, the subsections a and b are not repeated.

△ ABA form

In the example shown above, the larger A section is in E $\flat$ major. The B section is in A $\flat$ major.

Minuet

mf

3

Fine Trio

Da Capo al Fine

f

Subsections within larger forms are often repeated.

Faster rhythmic motion here, at the end of the A section

B section (Trio), in C major

△ AB subsections
Typical of the Classical period structure, the minuet (A) and trio (B) are each 16 measures long, and are divided into two subsections of eight-measure phrases, as seen in this excerpt from Mozart's K.1, A section (Minuet) in G major.